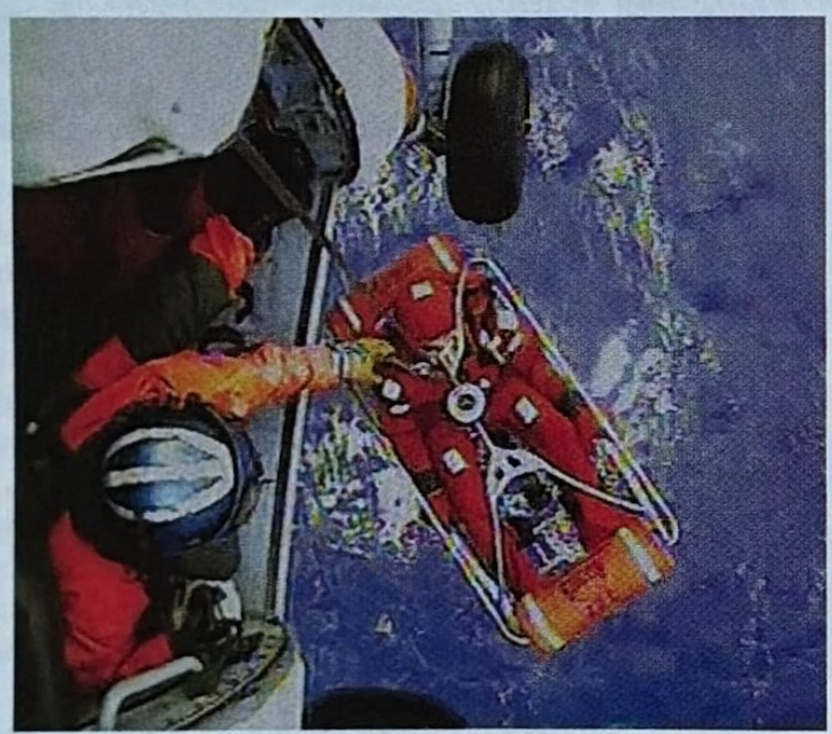
The candidates follow a strict daily regimen of physical conditioning, practicing rescue skills, and coursework, starting at 7 AM for up to three hours of dry-land training. Then they get in the water, where Kiest puts the group through excruciating physical paces. They swim sidestroke while holding a 10-pound brick aloft in one hand. "Buddy tows," pulling a partner in cross-chest carry for hundreds of yards, follow. Then they drop their bricks 12 feet to the bottom, shuttling them forward as far as they can before surfacing for a single breath of air. Kiest watches closely to make sure nobody takes two. He knows that no amount of instruction can prepare a class for the endless unpredictability of ocean rescues with life-or-death consequences. As if to remind himself of this, he has a tattoo on his calf: a pair of fins, a snorkel, and a mask clipped to a rescue hook, emblazoned with the A-School graduation numbers of the four swimmers who have died in the line of duty since the program's inception in 1984. The notion of self-sacrifice as the highest sort of valor is deeply held in the Rescue Swimmer community. It's even in their motto: "So others may live."

They have three opportunities to complete the non-compliant survivor test in less than seven minutes, or they'll fail.

One of the most dramatic examples of their mission occurred 100 miles due east of here, on October 29, 2012, during the devastation of Hurricane Sandy. Rescue swimmer Randy Haba was asleep on a couch in the Elizabeth City air station's lounge when an emergency page came in at 4:45 AM. A vessel off Cape Hatteras was taking on water. It was the HMS Bounty, a three-masted, 180-foot wooden tall ship, built in 1960 for the Marlon Brando epic *Mutiny on the Bounty*. There had been 16 people aboard. The crew had been forced to abandon ship. Daniel Todd, another rescue swimmer, was called in from home.

Ninety minutes later, hovering at 30 feet above raging 30-foot seas, with 75-mile-an-hour wind gusts, Haba was lowered by cable into the house-high waves. He swam to one crew member who was floating alone in his survival suit, semiconscious. Haba placed him in a rescue basket, and they were both hoisted from the waves. Haba was then lowered toward a life raft, rescuing four more crew members. Meanwhile, Todd was lowered into the same colossal waves, swimming to the side of a life raft and calling out, "Hi, I'm Dan. I heard you guys need a ride." (President Obama would repeat that story a few days later.) Todd rescued the remaining survivors. One crew member was found dead several hours later. Despite a 90-hour, 12,000-square-mile search, the Bounty's captain was never found.

For this A-School class, the noncompliant survivor test proves to be a heartbreaker. Of the five candidates left, two manage to rescue Jennison and pass the test: Piasecki and Via. Even for them, there will be many more tests in the weeks before they graduate, but they're over the hump. And after graduation there's EMT school, and Advanced Helicopter Rescue-Swimmer School, where they'll learn techniques for high-seas, cliff, and sea-cave rescues. They still have a journey before they're deployed. For the other candidates, failing is a deep disappointment after so much suffering. But it's not necessarily the end. Weeks later, Piasecki wrote in an email: "Most of them will try again; to have made it this far into the training, you have to be pretty dead-set on why you want to be here, and failing out is more of a motivator than a deterrent."



A crew member from the capsized HMS Bounty is lifted to a Coast Guard rescue helicopter during Hurricane Sandy, 90 miles east of Cape Hatteras.

As punishing as the program is, every instructor knows how much rougher and less predictable the ocean can be. For all its thunder and wind, the A-School pool is still a highly controlled environment within which to assess a swimmer's stress and endurance. As Randy Haba says, "If you have any doubts, it's better to find out here." ■

TECH

Preemptive Stripes

Can innovative new wetsuits help prevent shark attacks?

AROUND THE WORLD, shark attacks are on the rise. In the United States alone, the number of incidents nearly doubled from 2011 to 2012, and this year has already seen at least one fatality. To combat the problem, a firm in Australia has taken a unique approach: They've developed shark-deterring wetsuits.

The groundbreaking suits, which go for about $460, are based on new research indicating that sharks are likely color-blind. The first, dubbed the Diverter, has the striped appearance of a poisonous sea snake or lionfish. The second, the Elude, aims to make its wearer invisible. "Since we know what sharks see in different parts of the water column, we can re-create those effects," says Craig Anderson of Shark Mitigation Systems, which commissioned the research. "By matching the wetsuit to the palettes sharks perceive around them, we can hide in plain sight." Like camouflage worn by the military, future Elude patterns will vary by ocean and depth.

Some scientists are skeptical, such as George Burgess, head of the Florida Program for Shark Research, who believes stripes might actually *attract* sharks, as the animals see contrast especially well. But Anderson and his team have some compelling field tests to back up their claims. In footage viewable online, they fill a plastic drum with chum, then wrap it in standard black wetsuit material and lower it into the ocean, where a shark tears it to shreds; when the drum is covered in a new wetsuit pattern, a shark approaches but quickly jackknifes away.

"We're scientists who've been studying sharks for decades," Anderson says. "We saw the results, and now none of us will go in the water without one of these suits." —**JEFF FOSS**

FROM LEFT: COAST GUARD VIA RALEIGH NEWS & OBSERVER/MCT VIA GETTY IMAGES; COURTESY OF SHARK MITIGATION SYSTEMS